with the pennant and kettledrum, the regal standard and marching music that accompanied his journey, announcing the splendour of his rank and mission. Perhaps he nursed the hope that reports of his successes would flow to Akbar, composed in superlatives as if by his old Jesuit tutor, and bring a proud smile to his father's face.

Murad's campaign in Malwa was energetic; he showed no slackness in carrying out Akbar's commands. He had been sent to bring Raja Madhukar to heel, so when the raja hesitated in coming to pay homage to the newly arrived prince, Murad went chasing after him.

Badauni, when criticizing Murad's arrogance, adds the caveat that the prince, in his 'over-weaning pride . . . imitated his illustrious Father'.
There was certainly a hint of Akbar's reckless impatience in Murad's pursuit of Raja Madhukar. Abul Fazl, also critical, writes that Murad embarked on his chase 'without regard to his [own] rank', and one wonders how the historian could write the words without blushing, given how often and how glowingly he describes Akbar flouting exactly such objections from his worried chiefs.

At any rate, Murad's quick chase had its effect: before you knew it, the prince and his men had sacked the raja's home and Madhukar had fled.

News of his son's bravado did, indeed, reach Akbar; however, he was anything but pleased. Akbar was no longer the young padishah ridding his empire of rebels, and Raja Madhukar was not a discontented warlord. Murad had been too aggressive, Akbar said; the prince had broken agreements between the raja and the crown, he had 'without orders attacked the landowner'. Murad must fall back immediately, or Akbar would send an army against his own son.

Akbar knew how to delegate. He could not have built his empire without letting men like Todar Mal, Muzaffar Khan, Man Singh, Aziz Koka and Abdur Rahim do their jobs without too much interference. All of these men had displeased Akbar at one point or another; often they had been barred from court for their sins, but never threatened in the mortifying way that Akbar now threatened Murad.

Is it any wonder that when Father Xavier met the prince some three years later, he was more interested in hunting and lovemaking than impressing Akbar with a successful Deccan campaign? And little wonder, for that matter, that the Deccan campaign was a disaster.